

Melissa Perri's Post



Melissa Perri

1y



We've created a new version of the Product Death Cycle, and it's even more dangerous than the original.

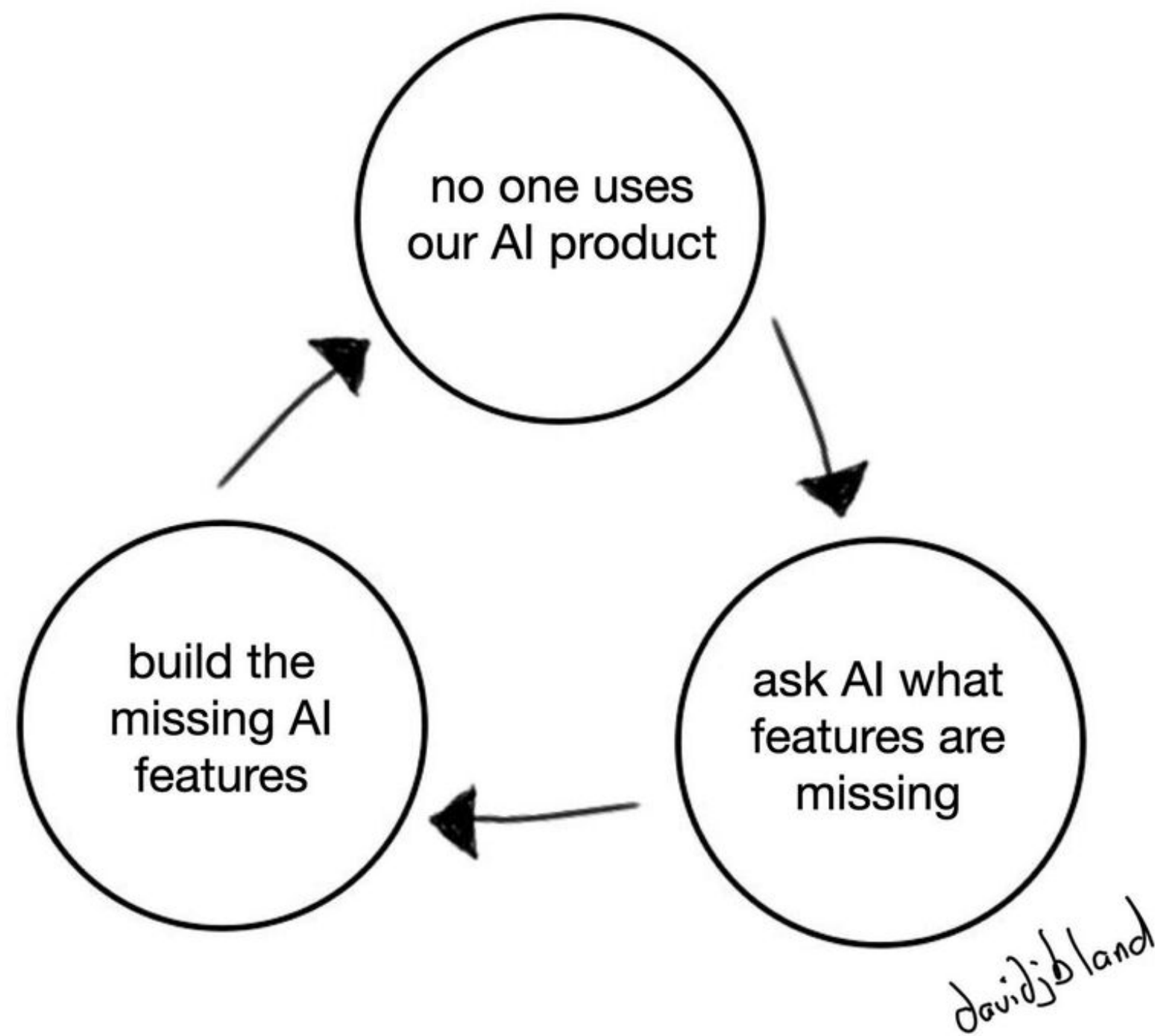
My friend [David Bland](#) created the Product Death Cycle that I featured in "Escaping the Build Trap". Recently, he shared an updated version that made me laugh and cry at the same time: no one uses our AI product → ask AI what features are missing → building the missing AI features → repeat 🤖

The irony is painful. Companies think they're being strategic by using AI to inform their roadmaps, but they're actually avoiding the fundamental work of understanding customer needs. It's the build trap with a shiny AI wrapper.

This new cycle is particularly dangerous because it feels data-driven. You're not just guessing what to build next or asking a single customer, you're asking AI! But you're still building without validating real user problems. The technology makes it cheaper and easier to ship useless software, so we're already seeing a graveyard of AI products and features that nobody wanted in the first place.

The solution isn't better AI features. It's better customer discovery. Talk to users, understand their problems, then decide if AI can actually solve them.

What's the most ridiculous AI product or feature you've seen shipped without clear user value?



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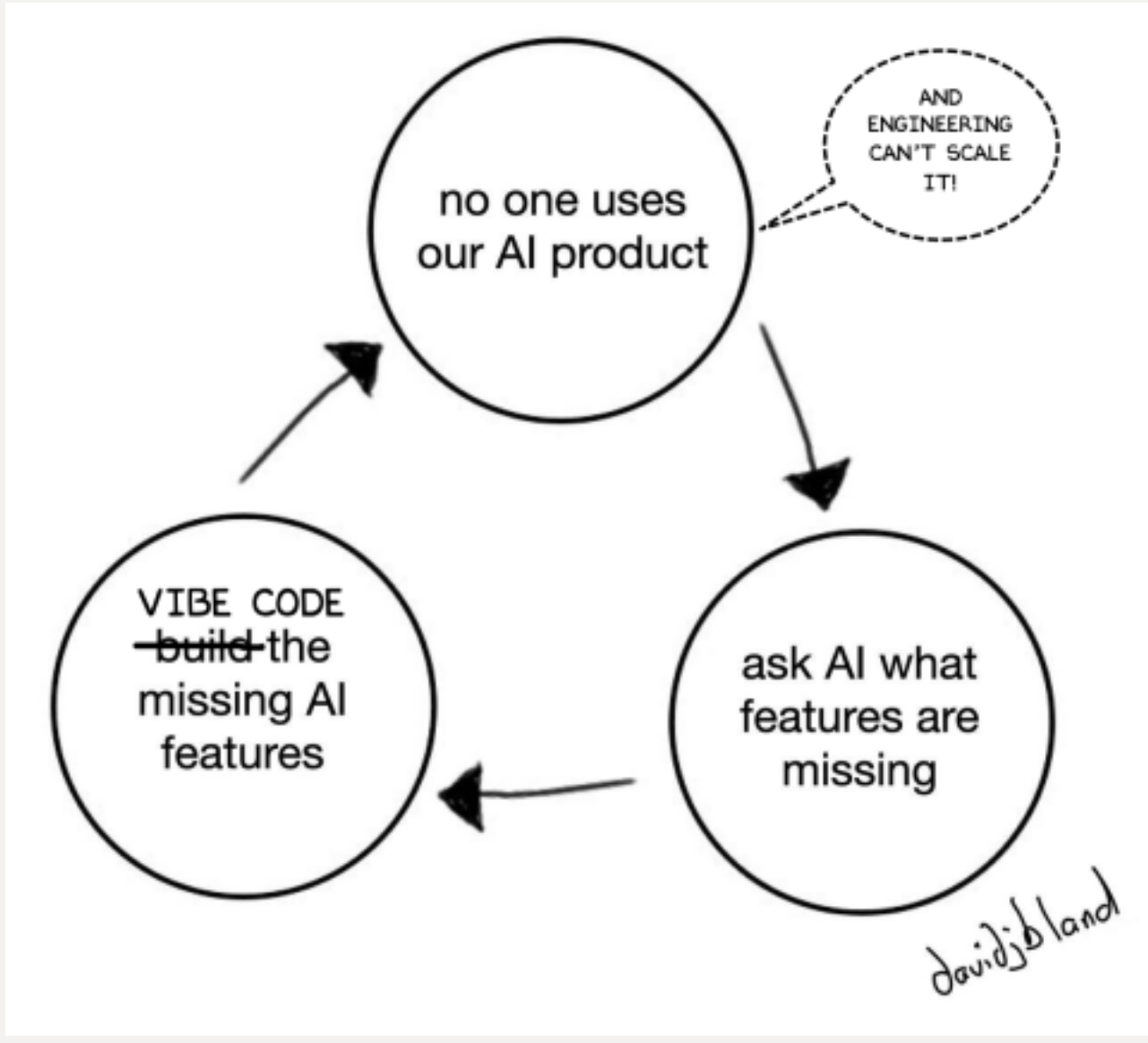


Dean Peters

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I made some "after market" tweaks ... hope y'all don't mind.



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Ellen Dirnberger

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Totally agree. To me, it always comes back to the humans, if we're not deeply understanding what people actually need, AI just becomes noise. Tech won't fix the gap if the real problems aren't uncovered first.

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Tony Walt

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Generative AI is going to change everything, but a lot of people are treating it like a checkbox for stock price and bonus season.

How do you slow down for thoughtful uses when the market rewards speed, even if it's in the wrong direction? I think of the principal that "Smooth is slow, and slow is fast". In the same regard, I worry that's only if you can survive the race.

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Gitumani Barman

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Very true, [Melissa](#)!! But what AI can help with is to take along a visible and working prototype to the customer discovery sessions, show them and ask whether it is really solving their pain points. AI can expedite the feedback loop!! A picture is worth a thousand words!!

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Ben Berkompas

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I'm reminded of Dr. Malcom's line from Jurassic Park: "Your scientists were so preoccupied with whether they could, they didn't stop to think if they should." GenAI provides endless opportunities to create things, but just because we \*can\* doesn't mean we \*should\*.

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Georgi N.

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You mean to tell me that not every person on Facebook uses Meta AI Studio daily? Shocker.  
The issue is that AI is still a fad which is oversold as a magic fix that executives believe.  
That's why we need data and only then, AI literacy.  
Most issues can be solved without AI (given you aren't doing AI for the PR of saying you are AI native)

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Anthony Villa

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Funny thing is we found the same issue with clients we work with at [inloop.studio](#) but on the CONSUMPTION side  
  
Business leaders onboarding AI solutions for their employees  
  
They go through a similar challenge of onboarding an AI solutions that doesn't solve anything and we help them Escape The Solution-First Trap.

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Nouran El-Behairy

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IMO the real conversation isn't whether AI should guide product roadmaps, but where it fits in discovery, we know that AI can accelerate pattern recognition, surface insights, and even structure research...etc but can it replace direct user conversations? and the real question is: at what point in discovery should teams lean on AI without losing the customer's voice?

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Geraldine Bauer

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I agree. Especially the part where people have the feeling that they are working "data driven", with the argument that AI is based on a lot of data.  
Personally, I find AI great as a "sparring partner" to gain inspiration at the beginning of my work and then to get feedback at the end of my work. In the specific example, I would use AI to ask about possible methods for surveying my users if I am currently lacking ideas or to check which statistical biases are influencing me in my evaluations.

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